

Mental Reset Routine for Weekend Runners

Step 1: Box Breathing (Breathwork)

Box breathing is a simple four-step breathing exercise where you inhale, hold, exhale, and hold for equal counts (for example, four seconds each). This technique resets your breathing after stressful experiences, clears your mind and calms your nervous system to improve focus and reduce stress.

Step 2: Visualization

Before your weekend run, take a minute to visualize yourself running smoothly and confidently—imagine overcoming hills and finishing strong. Regular mental rehearsal like this reduces anxiety, enhances motivation and primes your mind for peak performance during races.

Step 3: Journaling

After your run, spend 10–15 minutes jotting down how you felt physically and emotionally, noting any successes, challenges or surprising observations. Keeping a running journal helps you acknowledge hidden stressors, track subtle improvements and deepen self-awareness, which can reduce stress and clear your mind.

Bonus Mindset Tips

- **Practice mindfulness:** Short daily mindfulness or meditation sessions train your brain to stay present, reduce stress and increase clarity during runs.
- **Use positive self-talk:** Repeating affirmations and focusing on constructive feedback combats negative thoughts and boosts confidence and determination.
- **Pre-run body scan & gratitude:** Before lacing up, take a moment to notice any tightness or aches and appreciate what feels good; this simple check-in fosters

gratitude for what your body accomplishes.

Closing Note

As an amateur runner balancing work and life, you deserve a mental reset as much as a physical one. Incorporating this routine into your weekend runs will help you stay focused, enjoy the process and approach each outing with renewed confidence. Adjust the steps to suit your schedule, and remember that your mind is one of your strongest allies—nurture it, and your running will flourish.